The group was also easy to access because its above-ground JuD infrastructure remained legal, enabling Westerners to use its offices, mosques or madaris as initial entry points. The days of ‘walk-ins’ were over after 9/11, but Lashkar’s transnational networks, particularly among the Pakistani diaspora, enabled those seeking to train with it to make contact before arriving in Pakistan. For all of these reasons, it not only served as an appealing training provider, but also as a gateway organization to reach al-Qaeda. The examples that follow are not an exhaustive accounting of all those Westerners known to have trained with Lashkar after 9/11. Rather they are intended to illustrate the aforementioned attributes of those seeking training as well as of Lashkar as a training provider and gateway to al-Qaeda.

The case of Willie Brigitte demonstrates the impunity with which Lashkar operated after 9/11 and the degree to which this enabled it to provide training to a host of foreign recruits. Brigitte, a French convert to Islam, trained with the group for several months from late 2001 through early 2002. He was arrested in Australia in 2003, where he was involved in a terrorist plot connected to Lashkar. The details of this operation are discussed in the final section of this chapter. Relevant here is the information Brigitte provided during his interrogation in France, where he was deported to following his arrest in Australia. According to French authorities, when Brigitte presented himself to Lashkar for training he was debriefed for more than two weeks and asked to give names of fellow jihadis known to the group who could guarantee his bona fides. Once this initial round of vetting was complete, he was taken to a second camp where instructors debriefed him further for another fortnight. It was only after the group had confirmed he was not a French or American spy that Brigitte was introduced to the camp’s amir and allowed to commence training.[156]

When French magistrate Jean-Louis Bruguière interrogated Brigitte in 2003 the latter explained that he first underwent training in a camp near Lahore. He then was taken, along with two British and two American recruits, to the Bait-ul-Mujahideen in Pakistan-administered Kashmir. This road trip entailed crossing four army checkpoints ‘without any problems and without any identity checks.’ Brigitte testified to Bruguière that from there he went to a camp higher up in the mountains where he estimated several thousand Pakistanis and Afghans were training. He further testified that some of his instructors were soldiers on detachment and that Gulf